You Can Taste It

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Teen And Up Audiences

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by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

It's late in the evening at Catra and Adora's monthly party. A few people are settling down in the living room as the rest have left and gone to bed and the discussion, as it does, drifts to old times while Capella, only daughter of Bow and Glimmer, listens quietly.

Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the work for more notes

It was late. People were heading home while others were settling into the spare bedrooms that Catra and Adora had in their home. Some were even settling down in whatever shelters they cared to make where the edge of the Whispering Woods pushed up against the stone wall that marked the back edge of the property. In other words, it was a typical end to the monthly parties that Catra and Adora had been having at their home since they'd built it shortly after the war ended some decades back.

What else was typical was a few diehards settling down in the living room with the lights off as a few candles and oil lanterns burned and a few bottles came out of a cabinet in the wall. Bow did the first pour, knowing what each person in the room wanted without asking, before settling down on a couch as the light of a lantern caught in the ruby red liquid in his glass. Glimmer pulled up next to him as she took sip from her small glass full of a pink liquid that swirled with little inner currents.

"Good party," Bow said with a sigh as he leaned into Glimmer's arm that slid around his shoulder.

"Yeah," Catra said, nodding from her easy chair beside Adora's. She took a sip from the balloon glass in her hand and sighed. "That's the good stuff."

"I have no idea how you can drink that," Adora said, nodding at the brandy.

"Because it's good," Catra said before taking another sip. "And it's not pure sugar like that one."

She nodded at the wine glass full of a highly sweetened dessert wine Adora liked.

"It's not pure sugar. It's been fermented after all," Adora said.

"I remember the first time I saw you drink that," Scorpia said where she was half reclined on a couch. She had a large beer

stein in her claw as she went on. "It was that party right after the war at… I can't remember where."

"Tumble-Down-River," Bow said with a smile. "Didn't she drink three bottles?"

"Yeah! That place! That was a great place! And four is my memory," Scorpia said.

Everyone chuckled a little and Adora just shook her head.

"It wasn't that many."

"How about we ask the people of Tumble-Down-River?" Catra said with a grin. "Maybe they've forgot a drunk She-Ra by now but I doubt it."

"I wasn't that bad," Adora said with a roll of her eyes as she took a sip of her wine.

"You were that amusing," Glimmer said.

"I am a delight as a drunk," Adora said with a fake affronted dignity.

"You are a handful when you're drunk," Catra said with a snort.

"And you take like three people to move you when you're drunk," Glimmer said. "You do that boneless thing and just kind of flop around."

"Just leave me where I fall and you don't have to worry about it," Catra said.

"No, because then we have to listen to you snore," Bow said.

"I don't snore," Catra said.

"Yes, you do," several people said at once, setting off a round of laughs.

Tucked in beside the fireplace, Capella, Bow and Glimmer's only child, laughed as well. She was fifteen and had been determined to stay up tonight. No one had said anything to her yet and she was doing her best not to draw attention to herself but she had suffered through her Aunt Catra's occasional snoring bouts before.

"Hey, you don't get to laugh at your elders," Catra said with a grin as she pointed at Capella.

"Since when?" Capella shot back.

"She's got a point," Scorpia said, raising her mug at Capella like a little salute before taking a sip. "You never respected your elders."

Catra snorted as she said, "Yeah, but look at who my elders were and tell me I should have."

"No, because I'm not waking Perfuma up so she can deal with that," Scorpia said.

Catra grunted and took a sip of her brandy as Bow said, "Cappe, you sure you want to stay up with us?"

Capella shrugged as she said, "Can I get a drink?"

"No, you can not get a drink," Glimmer said.

"You can get a fizzy drink," Adora said.

"That's not what she meant," Glimmer replied.

"Maybe that's what I meant," Capella said.

"OK, then yes, you can go get a fizzy drink," Glimmer said with a little smile that said she knew full well that wasn't what Capella had meant.

"Grab me some of that bread and butter while you're at it," Catra said.

"Ooooo! And some pickles!" Scorpia put in.

"I'll take some of those olives too," Adora said. "And the mixed nuts."

"I'm not a waiter," Capella said.

"Yeah, but you're getting up anyway," Catra said.

Capella rolled her eyes as she said, "Dad, Mom? You want anything?"

"Just bring enough for everyone, please," Glimmer said.

"And some of the salami too!" Bow said.

Capella laughed and then with a flash she teleported to the kitchen. A few flashes later, she was sitting back where she'd been as she opened a bottle of orange fizzy drink and everyone else leaned forward to grab something to nibble on.

"You could have walked," Glimmer said.

"Please, I've seen you teleport two feet over to grab a pen," Catra said.

"Yeah, well my bad habits shouldn't be her bad habits," Glimmer said.

"I'm sure I'll have plenty of my own special bad habits," Capella responded. "Dad, I'm joking, get the look off your face."

"Hey, you remember Alm?" Catra suddenly said to Adora.

"Wait, what?" Adora said.

"Come on, keep up," Catra said. "Alm. You remember her?"

"You talking about the one who ran Third Squad?"

"Yes!"

"I remember her!" Scorpia said. "What does that have to do with Cappe?"

"Nothing, it just popped in my head. You remember that habit she had?" Catra said.

"Oh, the lucky socks," Adora said, her face scrunching up.

"What lucky socks?" Bow said.

"I can't believe in all these years I've never talked about her," Catra said. "OK, so she ran Third Squad of the 1st Horde Cadet Group. She was, I don't know, a year or so younger then us I think. Well, she always really wanted to be in command and when she got tapped for it, she was wearing these socks."

"It wasn't the socks, it was what…," Adora started to say before Catra waved a hand at her and cut her off.

"I know, I know, I'm telling this, alright?" Catra said. "So one of her squad mates told her, 'Hey, you must be wearing lucky socks!' She took that heart."

"How come I think I know where this is going?" Glimmer said.

"If it involves socks that had a stink like a physical presence, then yes, you know where it is going," Catra replied.

"She didn't wash them?" Bow said, his voice low in surprise.

"She did not," Scorpia said.

"She didn't wear them all the time, just whenever she felt like she needed to be lucky," Adora said.

"Which was usually in competitions or something," Catra said. "When tons of people were around."

"What happened?" Glimmer asked.

"She got some foot fungus that resisted all forms of treatment and it slowly ate her away until nothing was left but the socks which to this day are still roaming the dark hallways of the Fright Zone looking for its next victim," Catra said. Everyone laughed before Catra went on. "Naw, but she did get the fungus thing, got chewed out by one of the sergeants for it, and they made her wash them."

"Which is good, because you could taste those things in the air," Adora said.

"It wasn't that bad," Scorpia said. "You know she runs a chain of laundries now?"

"Of course you'd know what happened to her," Catra said with a smile.

"Wait, is this Alm of Alm's Bubble and Sud?" Bow said in surprise.

"That's her!" Scorpia said.

"I didn't even know she was a Horde cadet!" Bow said. "I've talked to her a few times at receptions at the castle."

"Ummm, maybe don't mention this story," Catra said.

"Come on, I'll tell her about it and then send her over the next time we see her," Glimmer said. "You can bond over old times."

Catra shook her head as she said, "No."

The no wasn't said strong and it wasn't said mean but it was said in such a way that it stopped conversation in the room. Catra didn't seem to notice at first as she took a drink. Capella scooted back into the corner a little more when Catra finally looked up.

"OK, that wasn't meant to kill the vibe," Catra said.

"Well, it's so awkward now you can taste it," Glimmer said.

"Phfftt, come on, it's not quite that bad," Scorpia said.

Catra just gave a little half smile before drinking back the rest of her brandy.

"You know what I remember?" No one spoke as Catra looked into her empty glass. "That taste you got right before a fight. Anyone remember that? That… I don't know, just you get that taste in your mouth, like you can feel the potential for violence settling on your tongue." She looked up and saw everyone looking at her. "Am the I only one?"

"I remember the fear," Bow said quietly. "That taste…"

"I know what you mean but no, this is something else," Catra said. "Maybe it was fear too, I don't know."

"I think I know what you mean," Scorpia said as Adora nodded along.

"Me too," Adora said as she took a breath and let it out before taking a sip of her wine. "It's that stillness too. That always got me. If it wasn't a surprise, if you saw it coming, you'd get that moment…"

She shook her head and took a drink again as Glimmer said, "That feeling, oof, damn, it's been what, over twenty years? I think about it and it's like it's right now. I remember on Prime's ship…," Glimmer said before her eyes flicked over to Capella before shaking her head and taking a sip of her glass that drained half of it. Capella was sure they'd change the subject or ask her to leave but no one said anything for a long moment.

"You know what's scarier?" Scorpia said softly. "When you don't feel it."

Her and Catra both reached up almost in unison to touch the base of their necks where the chips had rested and the scars, the physical ones at least, remained.

"You're right," Catra said as she got up to refill her glass. "I'd take all that again if it meant I never felt that blankness again."

"I don't even want to imagine," Bow said.

"And I'm glad you don't have to know," Catra said as she sat back down and held the glass up to look at the light of a candle through the amber liquid.

"I knew it wasn't right but it just felt…," Scorpia started to say before just trailing off.

Capella couldn't help herself as she said, "Felt what?"

Scorpia smiled sadly but shook her head as she said, "Nothing."

"Maybe this isn't the conversation for her," Glimmer said. Capella could feel the pain in the room and didn't even argue but then was surprised when her dad spoke up.

"No, it's OK," Bow said as he rested a hand on Glimmer's arm and looked at Capella. "You alright with this?"

"Yes," Capella said. "I'm sorry, I shouldn't have asked."

"It's alright," Scorpia said. "We're talking about it."

"And like we always said about Finn, if they're old enough to ask, they're old enough to have an answer," Catra said as Adora nodded. "I don't know what Scorpia was going to say, but I know it felt…," Catra stopped and took a deep breath as Adora reached over to take her hand. Catra squeezed back, took a sip of her brandy, and then said, "It felt like belonging, in the worst possible way you can ever imagine. You were… you were part of something and it wasn't right but it was and it just…"

Scorpia nodded as she said, "Yeah, just like that."

"It's over now though," Capella said and Catra nodded.

"It is. He's gone but you know, some things linger, even after their dead," Catra said.

"He's more than welcome to try and come back," Adora said and Capella felt her breath catch as she saw the absolute anger and hate change her aunt's face for a moment to something she'd never seen before and then it was just Adora again as Catra squeezed her hand again.

"Not what I meant, babe," Catra said.

"I know," Adora said with a thin smile. "I just…"

"No just," Bow said as he took a sip and sat up. "He's gone. We won in the end."

Catra raised her glass as she said, "Damn right we did. To the win."

"The win," the others echoed as they raised their drinks as well.

Capella didn't raise her drink, however, and Scorpia said, "You could have toasted as well."

"I know, it just… it didn't feel right," Capella said. "I wasn't there."

"Good," Bow said. "I hope you never have to know that what that's like, any of it."

"Same," Glimmer said. "You want excitement, taunt your Aunt Catra."

"I'm not crazy," Capella said with a wink at Catra who grinned back at her. "I'd pick Aunt Adora."

"OK, so you are crazy, just in a different way," Adora said with a laugh.

"Enough of this," Catra said. "Let me tell you what Adora did getting set up for the party today."

Adora rolled her eyes as Catra started telling the story with plenty of embellishments and the others laughed at each improbable bit Catra added on, as the previous conversation drifted off like a puff of smoke on the wind.

End Notes

Wow, it's been a while since I've written anything with Cappe. I have a lot of OCs I've created for my She-Ra stories over the years but Capella is one I've really got a lot into as I wrote so much about her and it was remarkably easy to slip back into her head. This is actually based on part of her story from when she's older (hence why it's in The In-Between series) and I briefly mention how she remembers Catra talking about how she could taste the potential for violence in the air. This has been on my WIP list for a few months now and I found it was time to write it. If you want to read more about her, she first appears as a minor character in Finn and the Moms of Power before getting her own series with The Heir Apparent. Thanks for reading!

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